natural world. The now prosperous middle classes were particularly inspired by Romantic portrayals of nature, and took up leisure pursuits such as hiking and mountaineering. The Romantic movement even affected scientific attitudes to nature by inspiring interest in the nascent field of ecology and the environmental movement.

The wild world

A key figure in the Romanticization of nature was Henry David Thoreau, an American writer from Concord, Massachusetts. His book *Walden* (1854) described his time living in a cabin in the woods by Walden Pond. Thoreau advocated preserving nature not for its own sake, but as a necessary resource in sustaining human life and a kind of spiritual enrichment. While Thoreau's "wilderness" was not far removed from modern life, his Romantic portrayal of the natural world significantly influenced the conservation movement in the US and helped inspire the National Parks system.